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INDIA'S MAHA KUMBH TO END WITH MAHA SHIVRATRI DIP TODAY

Pilgrims gather to take a holy dip in Sangam, the confluence of Ganga, Yamuna and mythical Saraswati rivers, on the eve of Maha Shivratri during the Maha Kumbh Mela festival in Prayagraj yesterday. The Maha Kumbh, which began on January 13, will conclude today, coinciding with Maha Shivratri. **SEE ALSO P13**

159 firms fined Dh50,000 each for violating UAE telemarketing rules

Dubai cracks down on unsolicited marketing calls

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

The Dubai Corporation for Consumer Protection and Fair Trade (DCCPFT) has imposed fines of Dh50,000 each on 159 companies for violating the UAE's recently-introduced telemarketing regulations. About 174 companies received warnings.

The penalties follow the introduction of strict telemarketing regulations under Cabinet Decision No. 56 of 2024, aimed at reducing intrusive sales calls

174
companies initially
issued warnings
by the authority

and safeguarding consumer privacy. Since the rules took effect in August 2024, authorities initially issued warnings to 174 companies, with 159 failing to comply and facing financial penalties.

Right of appeal

However, DCCPFT also provides companies with a legal mechanism to appeal fines. According to the new regu-

lations, key guiding principles for telemarketing activities include not contacting consumers whose numbers are registered in the 'Do Not Call Registry' (DNCR), which is managed by TDRA, only making calls from 9am to 6pm, and notifying the consumer at the start of the call if it's being recorded.

The Regulations also prohibit disclosing a consumer's personal data without their consent or trading it for re-processing by companies that wish to market their products or services through telemarketing.

The penalties vary depending on the violation's type and severity and the offence's repetition.

Ramadan gift: 55 mosques, English sermon in Dubai

Ongoing expansion includes UAE's first 3D-printed mosque

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

In an announcement that comes just ahead of Ramadan, Dubai revealed that it is constructing 55 new mosques and aims to expand Friday sermon translations into English across 70 per cent of mosques.

The Islamic Affairs and Charitable Activities Department (IACAD) in Dubai yesterday announced these developments. Mohammad Ali Bin Zayed Al Falasi, Executive Director of the Mosque Affairs Sector at IACAD, highlighted the department's vision to integrate traditional Islamic architecture with cutting-edge sustainability solutions.

As part of ongoing expansion,

Dubai inaugurated 24 mosques in 2024, built at a cost of Dh172 million. They can accommodate 13,911 worshippers.

Work in progress

Now, construction is underway for an additional 55 mosques, with an investment of Dh475 million. The new mosques will have the capacity to accommodate 40,961 worshippers across the emirate, IACAD revealed. Further pushing the boundaries of innovation, work commenced on the UAE's 'first 3D-printed mosque' expected to open in the second quarter of 2026.

Just a few days ahead of Ramadan, Dubai has seen the inauguration of two new mosques. The Ibrahim Ali Al Gergawi Mosque was inaugurated in Mirdif last week, while the Ata Al Rahman Mosque, located in Al Barsha (Arjan), was inaugurated on Sunday.

SEE ALSO P5

US backs Russia over Ukraine in split with allies

MACRON SAYS TRUCE COULD JUST BE 'WEEKS' AWAY AFTER TRUMP TALKS

NEW YORK

President Donald Trump deepened Washington's split with allies over Ukraine, withdrawing US condemnation of Russia's 2022 invasion at the United Nations and among Group of Seven countries as he aims to end the war on terms agreeable to Moscow.

In New York on Monday, the US and Russia both voted against an European-backed resolution in the UN General Assembly that calls out Moscow's "full-scale invasion" exactly three years ago. The two sides later aligned for the first time in the Security Council since the war started to approve a US resolution calling for a "swift end" to the conflict without assigning blame, a stark reversal from policy under President Joe Biden.

The G-7 also failed to issue a joint statement marking the third year since the start of the war, breaking with protocols in place since Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022.

"I would rather not explain it now but it's sort of self-evident," Trump said at the White House, when asked to explain the ra-

The G-7 also failed to issue a joint statement marking the third year since the start of the war, breaking with protocols.

tionale behind the US vote on the UN resolutions. He added that he wanted to discuss a separate resource deal with Russia as well.

French President Emmanuel Macron on Monday said a truce in the war in Ukraine could be possible in the coming weeks. A truce between Moscow and Kyiv "could be done in the weeks to come," Macron said in an interview with Fox News after a meeting on the conflict with US President Donald Trump in Washington.

In Russia, Putin offered to let US investors help develop mineral resources in Russia and parts of Ukraine it occupies, as well as being open to sell up to 2 million tons of aluminium to the US if sanctions are lifted. In comments to state television, he also welcomed Trump's proposal for talks on a 50 per cent cut in defence spending, which he called a "good idea."

— Agencies

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